

Graft Grips LEFT

For the first time in its history, a Politburo member is charged with corruption even as the deepening divide between rival factions tears the CPI(M) asunder

By M.G. Radhakrishnan

Through the many ups and downs in its 45-year history, the CPI(M) has always had impeccable credentials on two key counts—its faith in secularism and a strong anti-corruption platform. But as it enters its worst phase following the unprecedented rout in the Lok Sabha elections, the party appears to be losing the moral high ground it occupied. A disastrous alliance in Kerala with the People's Democratic Party of Abdul Nasser Madani, a rabid cleric, ripped apart the CPI(M)'s secular credentials. The CBI's decision last week to prosecute Pinarayi Vijayan, Kerala CPI(M) secretary and an accused in the Rs 340-crore SNC Lavalin scam, has punctured the party's claims to be the only clean outfit among India's corruption-ridden political parties. Vijayan has the dubious distinction of being the first Politburo member to be booked for corruption.

The CBI's decision to prosecute Vijayan—permission for which was given by state Governor R.S. Gavai—has triggered a huge political and legal storm in Kerala. In 1996, when Vijayan was the state power minister in the Left Democratic Front (LDF) government, a controversial contract was given to Canadian firm SNC Lavalin Inc. to renovate three hydropower houses. It is the CBI's contention that the contract amount was overestimated, causing a loss of about Rs 85 crore to the state.

The governor's sanction to prosecute Vijayan came after he rejected the state Cabinet's decision which held that the advocate general had already opined that the charges against Vijayan were politically motivated. The CPI(M) Politburo has vowed to

Photographs by SHANUAR



VIJAYAN AND
ACHUTHANANDAN
(RIGHT)



ACHUTHANANDAN IS ALL SMILES AS THE CBI READIES TO GRILL HIS RIVAL VIJAYAN IN THE RS 340-CRORE LAVALIN SCANDAL.

fight the charges, both legally and politically. In Kerala, the LDF Government has cancelled programmes involving the governor; party workers are busy taking out street protests and burning his effigies while the Raj Bhavan even received a phone call from Saudi Arabia threatening to kill Gavai.

"The governor has acted under pressure from the Congress at the state as well as the Centre," says Vaikom Viswan, LDF convener. "We will protect our secretary till the end." He has cited examples of cases

against Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati and Samajwadi party chief Mulayam Singh Yadav to prove the Congress' attempts to misuse the CBI against political opponents. "Why has the governor broken procedures and conveyed his opinion directly to CBI officials? Was it constitutional to bypass the state Cabinet and deal directly with CBI officials?" asks Kodiyeri Balakrishnan, Kerala home minister and CPI(M) Politburo member. CPI(M) leader P. Jayarajan has called Gavai a Congress stooge, saying that his son had unsuccessful-